

1970 NBA Finals

The **1970 NBA World Championship Series** was the championship series of the 1970 NBA playoffs, which concluded the 1969–70 National Basketball Association (NBA) season. The Eastern Division champion New York Knicks defeated the Western Division champion Los Angeles Lakers in seven games for their first NBA title.

The Knicks appeared to have a see-saw Game 3 won when Dave DeBusschere made a shot with three seconds left to give New York a 102–100 edge and the Lakers were stuck with no time outs. L.A. inbounded to Mr. Clutch, Jerry West, who launched and made a miracle shot from beyond midcourt. It counted only for two points, as only the ABA had a three-point shot at the time, so the game went to overtime, and the Knicks were able to win, 111–108.^[2]

The final game of the series was named by ESPN in 2010 as the greatest Game 7 in finals history, featuring a return from injury for Willis Reed.^[3] Reed's most famous performance took place on May 8, 1970, in Game 7 played at Madison Square Garden. Due to a severe thigh injury suffered in Game 5, a torn muscle that kept him out of Game 6, he was considered unlikely to play in Game 7. Yet Reed surprised the fans by walking onto the court during warmups, prompting widespread applause. Starting the game, he scored the Knicks' first two field goals on his first two shot attempts, his only points of the game.^[2] He then played defense on Wilt Chamberlain, limiting him to two shots made in nine attempts. When Reed left for good with 3:05 left in the first half, the Knicks led 61–37.^[4] Walt "Clyde" Frazier took it from there, finishing with 36 points and 19 assists as the Knicks won the championship, 113–99. Following the game in the winner's locker room, a moved Howard Cosell told Reed on national television, "You exemplify the very best that the human spirit can offer."^[2] ESPN's *SportsCentury Top 10 Games of the 20th Century* ranked Game 7 the 9th Greatest Game in 1999.

Background

New York Knicks

1969–70 New York Knicks roster		
Players		Coaches

1970 NBA Finals

Team	Coach	Wins
<u>New York Knicks</u>	<u>Red Holzman</u>	4
<u>Los Angeles Lakers</u>	<u>Joe Mullaney</u>	3
Dates	April 24 – May 8	
MVP	<u>Willis Reed</u> ^[1] (<u>New York Knicks</u>)	
Hall of Famers	Knicks: <u>Willis Reed</u> (1982) <u>Bill Bradley</u> (1983) <u>Dave DeBusschere</u> (1983) <u>Walt Frazier</u> (1987) <u>Phil Jackson</u> (2007, coach) <u>Dick Barnett</u> (2024) Lakers: <u>Elgin Baylor</u> (1977) <u>Wilt Chamberlain</u> (1979) <u>Jerry West</u> (1980) Coaches: <u>Red Holzman</u> (1986) Officials: <u>Mendy Rudolph</u> (2007)	
Eastern finals	<u>Knicks</u> defeated <u>Bucks</u> , 4–1	
Western finals	<u>Lakers</u> defeated <u>Hawks</u> , 4–0	

<u>Pos.</u> ♦	<u>No.</u> ♦	<u>Player</u> ♦	<u>Height</u> ♦	<u>Weight</u> ♦	<u>DOB</u> ♦	<u>From</u> ♦	<u>Head coach</u>
<u>SG</u>	12	<u>Dick Barnett</u>	6 ft 4 in (1.93 m)	190 lb (86 kg)	1936–10–02	<u>Tennessee State</u>	▪ <u>Red Holzman</u>
<u>C</u>	17	<u>Nate Bowman</u>	6 ft 10 in (2.08 m)	230 lb (104 kg)	1945–03–19	<u>Wichita State</u>	Legend
<u>SF</u>	24	<u>Bill Bradley</u>	6 ft 5 in (1.96 m)	205 lb (93 kg)	1943–07–28	<u>Princeton</u>	▪ (DP) Unsigned draft pick
<u>PF</u>	22	<u>Dave DeBusschere</u>	6 ft 6 in (1.98 m)	220 lb (100 kg)	1940–10–16	<u>Detroit Mercy</u>	▪ (FA) Free agent
<u>PG</u>	10	<u>Walt Frazier</u>	6 ft 4 in (1.93 m)	200 lb (91 kg)	1945–03–29	<u>Southern Illinois</u>	▪ (S) Suspended
<u>PF</u>	20	<u>Bill Jr. Hosket</u>	6 ft 8 in (2.03 m)	225 lb (102 kg)	1946–12–20	<u>Ohio State</u>	▪ + Injured
<u>PF</u>	18	<u>Phil Jackson</u> (IN)	6 ft 8 in (2.03 m)	220 lb (100 kg)	1945–09–17	<u>North Dakota</u>	
<u>SF</u>	5	<u>Don May</u>	6 ft 4 in (1.93 m)	200 lb (91 kg)	1946–01–03	<u>Dayton</u>	
<u>C</u>	19	<u>Willis Reed</u>	6 ft 9 in (2.06 m)	235 lb (107 kg)	1942–06–25	<u>Grambling State</u>	
<u>SG</u>	6	<u>Mike Riordan</u>	6 ft 4 in (1.93 m)	200 lb (91 kg)	1945–07–09	<u>Providence</u>	
<u>SF</u>	33	<u>Cazzie Russell</u>	6 ft 5 in (1.96 m)	218 lb (99 kg)	1944–06–07	<u>Michigan</u>	
<u>SF</u>	9	<u>Dave Stallworth</u>	6 ft 7 in (2.01 m)	200 lb (91 kg)	1941–12–20	<u>Wichita State</u>	
<u>SG</u>	16	<u>John Warren</u>	6 ft 3 in (1.91 m)	180 lb (82 kg)	1947–07–07	<u>St. John's</u>	

Los Angeles Lakers

1969–70 Los Angeles Lakers roster							
Players							Coaches
<u>Pos.</u> ♦	<u>No.</u> ♦	<u>Player</u> ♦	<u>Height</u> ♦	<u>Weight</u> ♦	<u>DOB</u> ♦	<u>From</u> ♦	<u>Head coach</u>
<u>SF</u>	22	<u>Elgin Baylor</u>	6 ft 5 in (1.96 m)	225 lb (102 kg)	1934–09–16	<u>Seattle</u>	▪ <u>Joe Mullaney</u>
<u>C</u>	13	<u>Wilt Chamberlain</u>	7 ft 1 in (2.16 m)	275 lb (125 kg)	1936–08–21	<u>Kansas</u>	Legend
<u>C</u>	31	<u>Mel Counts</u>	7 ft 0 in (2.13 m)	230 lb (104 kg)	1941–10–16	<u>Oregon State</u>	▪ (DP) Unsigned draft pick
<u>PG</u>	21	<u>Johnny Egan</u>	5 ft 11 in (1.80 m)	180 lb (82 kg)	1939–01–31	<u>Providence</u>	▪ (FA) Free agent
<u>SF</u>	24	<u>Keith Erickson</u>	6 ft 5 in (1.96 m)	195 lb (88 kg)	1944–04–19	<u>UCLA</u>	▪ (S) Suspended
<u>SG</u>	20	<u>Dick Garrett</u>	6 ft 3 in (1.91 m)	185 lb (84 kg)	1947–01–31	<u>Southern Illinois</u>	▪ + Injured
<u>PF</u>	52	<u>Happy Hairston</u>	6 ft 7 in (2.01 m)	225 lb (102 kg)	1942–05–31	<u>NYU</u>	
<u>PF</u>	30	<u>Bill Hewitt</u>	6 ft 7 in (2.01 m)	210 lb (95 kg)	1944–08–08	<u>USC</u>	
<u>SF</u>	33	<u>Mike Lynn</u>	6 ft 7 in (2.01 m)	215 lb (98 kg)	1945–11–25	<u>UCLA</u>	
<u>SG</u>	15	<u>Willie McCarter</u>	6 ft 3 in (1.91 m)	175 lb (79 kg)	1946–07–26	<u>Drake</u>	

Pos. ◆	No. ◆	Player ◆	Height ◆	Weight ◆	DOB ◆	From ◆
<u>C</u>	35	<u>Rick Roberson</u>	6 ft 9 in (2.06 m)	231 lb (105 kg)	1947-07-07	<u>Cincinnati</u>
<u>PF</u>	14	<u>John Tresvant</u>	6 ft 7 in (2.01 m)	215 lb (98 kg)	1939-11-06	<u>Seattle</u>
<u>PG</u>	44	<u>Jerry West</u>	6 ft 3 in (1.91 m)	175 lb (79 kg)	1938-05-28	<u>West Virginia</u>

Series summary

Game	Date	Road team	Result	Home team
Game 1	April 24	Los Angeles Lakers	112–124 (0–1)	New York Knicks
Game 2	April 27	Los Angeles Lakers	105–103 (1–1)	New York Knicks
Game 3	April 29	New York Knicks	112–108 (OT) (2–1)	Los Angeles Lakers
Game 4	May 1	New York Knicks	115–121 (OT) (2–2)	Los Angeles Lakers
Game 5	May 4	Los Angeles Lakers	100–107 (2–3)	New York Knicks
Game 6	May 6	New York Knicks	113–135 (3–3)	Los Angeles Lakers
Game 7	May 8	Los Angeles Lakers	99–113 (3–4)	New York Knicks

Knicks win series 4–3

Source:^[5]

Game summaries

Game 1

April 24	<u>Boxscore</u> (http://www.basketball-reference.com/boxscores/197004240_NYK.html)	Los Angeles Lakers 112, <u>New York Knicks 124</u> Scoring by quarter: 25– 35 , 29– 30 , 38–24, 20– 35 Pts: <u>Jerry West</u> 33 Pts: <u>Willis Reed</u> 37 Rebs: <u>Wilt Chamberlain</u> 24 Rebs: <u>Reed</u> , <u>DeBusschere</u> 16 each Asts: <u>Wilt Chamberlain</u> 5 Asts: <u>Dick Barnett</u> 9 <i>New York leads series, 1–0</i>	Madison Square Garden, New York City, New York Attendance: 19,500
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Game 2

April 27	<u>Boxscore</u> (http://www.basketball-reference.com/boxscores/197004270_LAL.html)	Los Angeles Lakers 105, New York Knicks 103 Scoring by quarter: 28–24, 24– 28 , 29–29, 24–22 Pts: <u>Jerry West</u> 34 Pts: <u>Willis Reed</u> 29 Rebs: <u>Wilt Chamberlain</u> 24 Rebs: <u>Willis Reed</u> 15 Asts: <u>Garrett</u> , <u>Erickson</u> 6 each Asts: <u>Walt Frazier</u> 11 <i>Series tied, 1–1</i>	Madison Square Garden, New York City, New York Attendance: 19,500
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Game 3

April 29

Boxscore
(<http://www.basketball-reference.com/boxscores/197004290/LAL.html>)

New York Knicks 111, Los Angeles Lakers 108 (OT)

Scoring by quarter: 20–26, 22–30, 26–17, 34–29, **Overtime:** 9–6

Pts: Willis Reed 38 **Pts:** Jerry West 34
Rebs: Willis Reed 17 **Rebs:** Wilt Chamberlain 26
Asts: Walt Frazier 7 **Asts:** Elgin Baylor 11

New York leads series, 2–1

The Forum, Inglewood, California
Attendance: 17,509

- Jerry West hit a desperation buzzer-beating 60-foot shot to tie it at 102 and force OT. If a three-point line had existed at the time, it would've won the game for the Lakers and potentially the Finals, likely going to down as the greatest shot in NBA history.^[6]

Game 4

May 1

Boxscore
(<http://www.basketball-reference.com/boxscores/197005010/LAL.html>)

New York Knicks 115, Los Angeles Lakers 121 (OT)

Scoring by quarter: 27–24, 20–30, 20–17, 32–28, **Overtime:** 16–22

Pts: Dick Barnett 29 **Pts:** Jerry West 37
Rebs: Dave Stallworth 13 **Rebs:** Wilt Chamberlain 25
Asts: Walt Frazier 11 **Asts:** Jerry West 18

Series tied, 2–2

The Forum, Inglewood, California
Attendance: 17,509

Game 5

May 4

Boxscore
(<http://www.basketball-reference.com/boxscores/197005040/NYK.html>)

Los Angeles Lakers 100, New York Knicks 107

Scoring by quarter: 30–20, 23–20, 29–35, 18–32

Pts: Wilt Chamberlain 22 **Pts:** Walt Frazier 21
Rebs: Wilt Chamberlain 19 **Rebs:** Cazzie Russell 8
Asts: Keith Erickson 6 **Asts:** Walt Frazier 12

New York leads series, 3–2

Madison Square Garden, New York City, New York
Attendance: 19,500

Game 6

May 6

Boxscore (http://www.basketball-reference.com/boxscores/19705060LAL.html)	New York Knicks 113, Los Angeles Lakers 135 Scoring by quarter: 16–36, 35–35, 29–28, 33–36 Pts: Dave DeBusschere 25 Pts: Wilt Chamberlain 45 Rebs: Dave DeBusschere 9 Rebs: Wilt Chamberlain 27 Asts: Dick Barnett 8 Asts: Jerry West 13 Series tied, 3–3	The Forum, Inglewood, California Attendance: 17,509
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Game 7

May 8	Boxscore (http://www.basketball-reference.com/boxscores/19705080NYK.html)	Los Angeles Lakers 99, New York Knicks 113 Scoring by quarter: 24–38, 18–31, 27–25, 30–19 Pts: Jerry West 28 Pts: Walt Frazier 36 Rebs: Wilt Chamberlain 24 Rebs: Dave DeBusschere 17 Asts: Keith Erickson 6 Asts: Walt Frazier 19 New York wins series, 4–3	Madison Square Garden, New York City, New York Attendance: 19,500 Referees: - No. 5 Mendy Rudolph - No. 26 Richie Powers
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During the pre-game segment with [Chris Schenkel](#), [Jack Twyman](#) noticed Knicks' injured center [Willis Reed](#) (whose status for the clincher had been doubtful) advancing from the tunnel toward the court.

Twyman then exclaimed: "*I think we see Willis coming out!*"^[7] The sight of Reed marching toward the basketball floor helped inspire the Knicks to a 113–99 victory – one that gave New York its first NBA league title.

[Walt "Clyde" Frazier](#) went on to post one of the greatest performances in NBA playoff history, tallying 36 points, seven rebounds, 19 assists, and six steals in leading New York to victory.

External videos

 Full game broadcast (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZiWzpl_bxKM) on YouTube

Television

The 1970 NBA Finals were the first to be nationally televised in full, with [ABC](#) providing the coverage. [Chris Schenkel](#) was the play-by-play man, with [Jack Twyman](#) serving as the color analyst. [Howard Cosell](#) provided interviews from the Knicks' locker room following Game 7 and was famously doused with champagne.

However, the Knicks' victory in Game 7 was not seen live on broadcast TV in New York; ABC's coverage was blacked out on [WABC-TV](#), causing a raft of angry fans to deluge the WABC switchboard. Schenkel made an announcement during the broadcast that the game would be aired in New York at 11:30 p.m. that night. The game *was* shown live on the premium-channel [MSG Network](#) in New York City, which was then only available in about 25,000 cable households in Manhattan.

Since the 1970 finals, every NBA Finals game has been carried across the United States, though local blackouts would take some time to subside.

Player statistics

Legend					
GP	Games played	GS	Games started	MPG	Minutes per game
FG%	Field-goal percentage	3P%	3-point field-goal percentage	FT%	Free-throw percentage
RPG	Rebounds per game	APG	Assists per game	SPG	Steals per game
BPG	Blocks per game	PPG	Points per game		

New York Knicks

New York Knicks statistics											
Player	GP	GS	MPG	FG%	3P%	FT%	RPG	APG	SPG	BPG	PPG
Willis Reed	6		37.7	.484		.588	10.5	2.8			23.0
Dave DeBusschere	7		38.1	.455		.722	12.6	2.6			19.0
Dick Barnett	7		40.6	.448		.897	2.3	4.3			18.6
Walt Frazier	7		43.1	.541		.775	7.7	10.4			17.6
Bill Bradley	7		35.6	.388		.750	4.0	2.7			12.1
Cazzie Russell	7		18.6	.492		1.000	3.6	1.4			9.3
Dave Stallworth	7		14.0	.447		1.000	4.7	1.6			7.0
Mike Riordan	7		13.0	.387		.857	1.9	1.4			4.3
Nate Bowman	7		9.7	.481		.600	3.0	0.3			4.1
Bill Hosket	2		4.5	.250			0.5	0.5			1.0
John Warren	4		1.5	1.000			0.0	0.3			0.5

Los Angeles Lakers

Los Angeles Lakers statistics

Player	GP	GS	MPG	FG%	3P%	FT%	RPG	APG	SPG	BPG	PPG
<u>Jerry West</u>	7		47.9	.450		.833	3.4	7.7			31.3
<u>Wilt Chamberlain</u>	7		47.6	.625		.343	24.1	4.0			23.3
<u>Elgin Baylor</u>	7		40.0	.486		.778	11.3	4.7			17.9
<u>Dick Garrett</u>	7		36.7	.474		.944	3.0	2.1			13.0
<u>Keith Erickson</u>	7		38.7	.479		.722	4.4	4.7			11.6
<u>Happy Hairston</u>	6		17.5	.471		.636	4.3	1.5			6.5
<u>Johnny Egan</u>	7		10.3	.526		1.000	0.1	0.9			3.6
<u>John Tresvant</u>	4		9.3	.333		.800	2.8	1.3			4.5
<u>Mel Counts</u>	3		9.0	.357		.667	2.7	0.3			4.0
<u>Rick Roberson</u>	3		3.3	.500		.500	1.3	0.0			2.3
<u>Mike Lynn</u>	1		1.0				0.0	0.0			0.0
<u>Willie McCarter</u>	1		2.0	.000			1.0	1.0			0.0

Source:^[5]

References

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6. Dizon, Orel (November 1, 2023). "'We were lucky that there were no 3-point shots back then' - Walt Frazier on Jerry West's 60-foot buzzer-beater in the 1970 Finals" (<https://www.basketballnetwork.net/latest-news/walt-frazier-on-jerry-wests-60-foot-buzzer-beater-in-the-1970-finals#:~:text=West's%20shot%20sent%20Game%203,lead%20in%20the%201970%20Finals.&text=The%201970%20NBA%20Finals%20brought,%22>). *Basketball Network*. Retrieved January 16, 2025.
7. Video (<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SeITaf3e2Uo>) on YouTube

External links

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